The Knowledge Argument and Sensational Surprise

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a Response to Question 2

The problems that plagued property dualism led to a rise in of predominantly materialist positions in philosophy. Though there were attempts to defend the mentalist view of the mind-body problem, none has garnered as much popularity (and dispute) as Jackson's (1982) Knowledge Argument. This essay aims to explain and defend the Knowledge Argument against one such disputation posed by the Acquaintance Hypothesis through the analogy of the Overview Effect, which is the subjective response astronauts have while viewing the Earth from space.

Jackson's Knowledge Argument

Frank Jackson's (1982) Knowledge Argument is a defence of epiphenomenalism, which is the view that mental properties are a by-product of physical events and do not directly cause any physical events – that is, they are causally inefficacious. He argues that the *existence* of mental properties, which exist outside of the bounds of physical information, cannot be contested. The physical, according to Jackson, includes the broad range of facts provided to us by science. This is the only objectively 'correct' information in the view of the Physicalist doctrine.

However, Jackson believes that this physical information insufficient in describing the entirety of conscious experience. He lays down a simple formula: there is no physical information, no matter how much or how well-formulated, that can adequately describe certain perceptual experiences, like the smell of a rose or (for example) how it feels to view the planet Earth from space. These experiences, or 'qualia', are thus nonphysical.

He further proposes two thought experiments relating to colour vision to illustrate this point. In the first, he proposes the case of a man Fred, who can see shades of the colour red as

separate colours, in the same way a normal human being can differentiate between the colours yellow and blue. No amount of surgeries or experiments which examine his optical physiology allow another human to see such colour, short of transplanting Fred's eyes into another person. If all physical information regarding Fred is known, but knowledge of the colours and their impressions still remain elusive, it follows that physical information is not sufficient to qualify conscious experience.

Jackson's second and far more prolific thought experiment uses the example of Mary, an extremely smart scientist, who is forced to remain in a black-and-white room. She is given all physical information about the world outside her room, including facts about flowers' scents and views from spaceships, which she dutifully studies. She knows how human physiology interacts with the physical world and how it assimilates sensations. What happens when Mary is allowed to go out into the world, after all this?

It is intuitive that her experience of the world in colour as compared to the black-and-white room is fundamentally different. No amount of physical information could replicate the exact experience of seeing colour for the first time. Jackson argues that if Mary, who has all the physical knowledge in the world, learns something new when she leaves the room, then the Physicalist picture is incomplete. This argument was later formalized as follows (Jackson, 1986; Tang, 2021):

1) Mary (before her release) knows everything physical there is to know about other people.
2) Mary (before her release) does not know everything there is to know about other people (because she learns something about them on being released).
3) Therefore, there are truths [facts] about other people (and herself) that escape the physicalist story (1,2).

Conee's Acquaintance Hypothesis

Since the first premise (though not free from scepticism) is true *ex hypothesi*, contestations to the Knowledge Argument aim to poke holes in the second premise. This is typically achieved by making distinctions in the nature of what kind of novel experience Mary has had – it is granted that she gains something new once she steps out of the room, but not that this new information is a physical fact.

The Acquaintance Hypothesis, as presented by Earl Conee, makes such an argument. He grants that Mary does acquire something new when she steps out of her room, but this knowledge is that of acquaintance, which necessitates a direct interaction with something to become familiar with it (Conee, 1994 as in Tang, 2021). Mary-in-the-room had propositional knowledge (or 'knowledge-that', which can be expressed as statements – like "Mary has knowledge that the Earth is round."), not knowledge by acquaintance, which is only acquired through direct experience.

She learns no new factual, propositional knowledge. And since becoming acquainted with something is not learning a new fact about it, Conee argues that Physicalism still stands. This argument has been formalized as follows (Nida-Rümelin & O Conaill, 2019):

1) Experiences are physical processes and qualia are physical properties of experiences. Let *Q* be such a property.
2) Mary (before her release) can know all about *Q* and she can know that a given experience has *Q* before release, although she is not acquainted with *Q*.
3) After release Mary gets acquainted with *Q*, but she does not acquire any new item of propositional knowledge by getting acquainted with *Q* (in particular she already knew under what conditions normal perceivers have experiences with the property *Q*) (1,2).

Virtual Acquaintance

Conee's argument hinges on the fact that experiences are not objective, thus do not qualify as physical 'facts'. In his view, Mary is not learning something new, merely familiarizing herself with what she already knows through direct interaction. For instance, I am told that there is a song playing on the radio, and I believe this information. When I turn on the radio and hear the song, I should not learn anything new. Though I personally did not know the song was on prior (I was merely given this information), I am not surprised that it is playing.

Similarly, if Mary learns nothing new, she has no reason to be surprised when she leaves the room. But it seems obvious that Mary is surprised when she steps out of her room, despite having physical knowledge of everything she might encounter, and this surprise can only be attributed to her learning something new. That qualia are not universally objective is irrelevant – if she learns something new through her experience, the Knowledge Argument holds true.

The Acquaintance Hypothesis emphasizes that qualia allow us to acquire something new due to a direct, physical sensation that was previously unexperienced (Premise 1), and Mary's surprise may thus be explained away by her direct awareness of physical sensations caused by seeing the colour red. But what if she experienced these physical sensations prior to her release in the real world, and was still shocked?

Let us return briefly to the Overview Effect touched upon in the beginning of the essay. The Overview Effect refers to the subjective response of overwhelming feelings of awe, fragility, and clarity that astronauts reported when they saw the Earth from space for the first time. In preparation for their expedition to space, astronauts undergo training in virtual reality, which includes footage from satellites that show how Earth looks from space.

Virtual reality, by its very nature, elicits the same physical sensations in the body and the brain that would be produced of a person was confronted with that object or circumstance in real life. It fulfils the requirement of having the physical processes of experience that the proponents of the Acquaintance Hypothesis attribute to qualia. However, astronauts report that the Overview Effect is qualitatively different when experienced in-person versus in virtual reality.

It stands to reason that there is *something* that physical sensation is not responsible for. The knowledge that one is real, and the other is not is a decisive factor in the conscious experience of the Overview Effect, and this knowledge cannot be anything but nonphysical. Though the astronauts are intimately familiar with the visual experience of seeing Earth from space, they are still surprised when they see the real thing; thus, qualia are necessarily nonphysical in nature.

This argument can be formalized as follows:

1) Experiences are physical processes and qualia are physical properties of experiences (by Acquaintance Hypothesis).
2) Astronauts (while on Earth) are acquainted with the physical experience of seeing the Earth from space.
3) Astronauts are experience a new subjective response (the Overview Effect) when they see the Earth from space.
4) Therefore, there are experiences that are not purely derived from physical sensations (1,2,3).

Conclusion

Jackson's thought experiment of Mary's Room and proposal of the Knowledge Argument defend the existence of mental properties, by arguing that no amount of objective physical information can satisfactorily replicate the experience of qualia. The Acquaintance

Hypothesis attempts to block this argument by asserting a difference between learning new knowledge and familiarizing oneself with the direct awareness of prior knowledge caused by novel physical sensations. However, this falls short on two counts – first, that familiarity does not presume surprise (and Mary is surprised when she leaves her room) and second, that qualia are not bound to physical sensations (as seen through the Overview Effect).

References

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